DES205 Portfolio

Nicole Meenan

Brief and Concept

The brief I had chosen for my level was phycology with a focus on evoking phobias.

The concept idea that I came up with is a multiple story building, where each level represents a different phobia. The player must find a key-card hidden within each floor which will activate the locked elevator, allowing the player to progress to each level. There will be no actual threats or danger in the level, more of just an aesthetic experience and a good scare. This suits the brief as it taps into the psyche of the player and makes them feel threatened even though there is no real danger.

Moodboard



(SadSquare Studio, 2018)

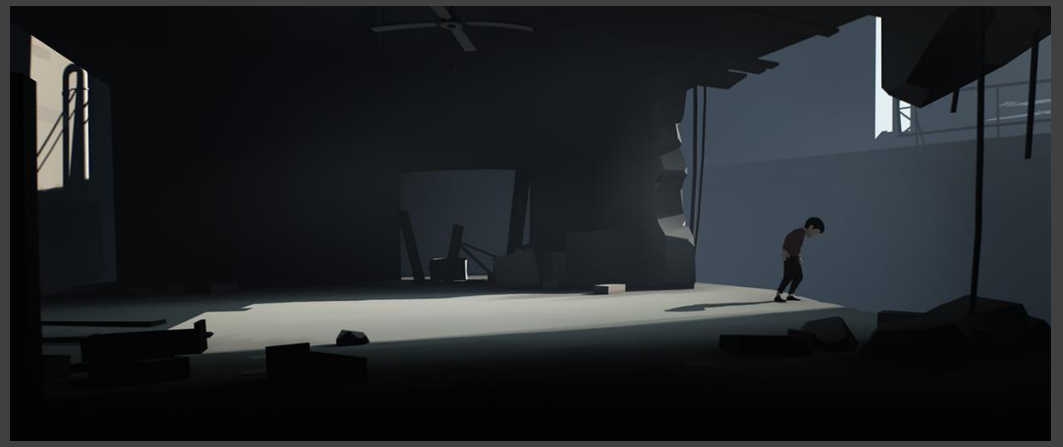


(Kazuhiro Hamatani, 2015)



(Bloober Team, 2016)

Visage (SadSqaure Studio, 2018) is a game that I found did a great job at tapping into different fears and phobias whilst incorporating tricky puzzles for the player to solve. As well as *Bloodborne* (Kazuhiro Hamatani, 2015) which I found had very effective visuals. Mostly the aesthetics of my game is inspired by *Inside* (Playdead, 2016) as the use of lighting is phenomenal. I can appreciate the mind games that *Layers of fear (Bloober Team, 2016)* has on the player. This is a very effective way to do horror as having the player confused as well as scared increases vulnerability.



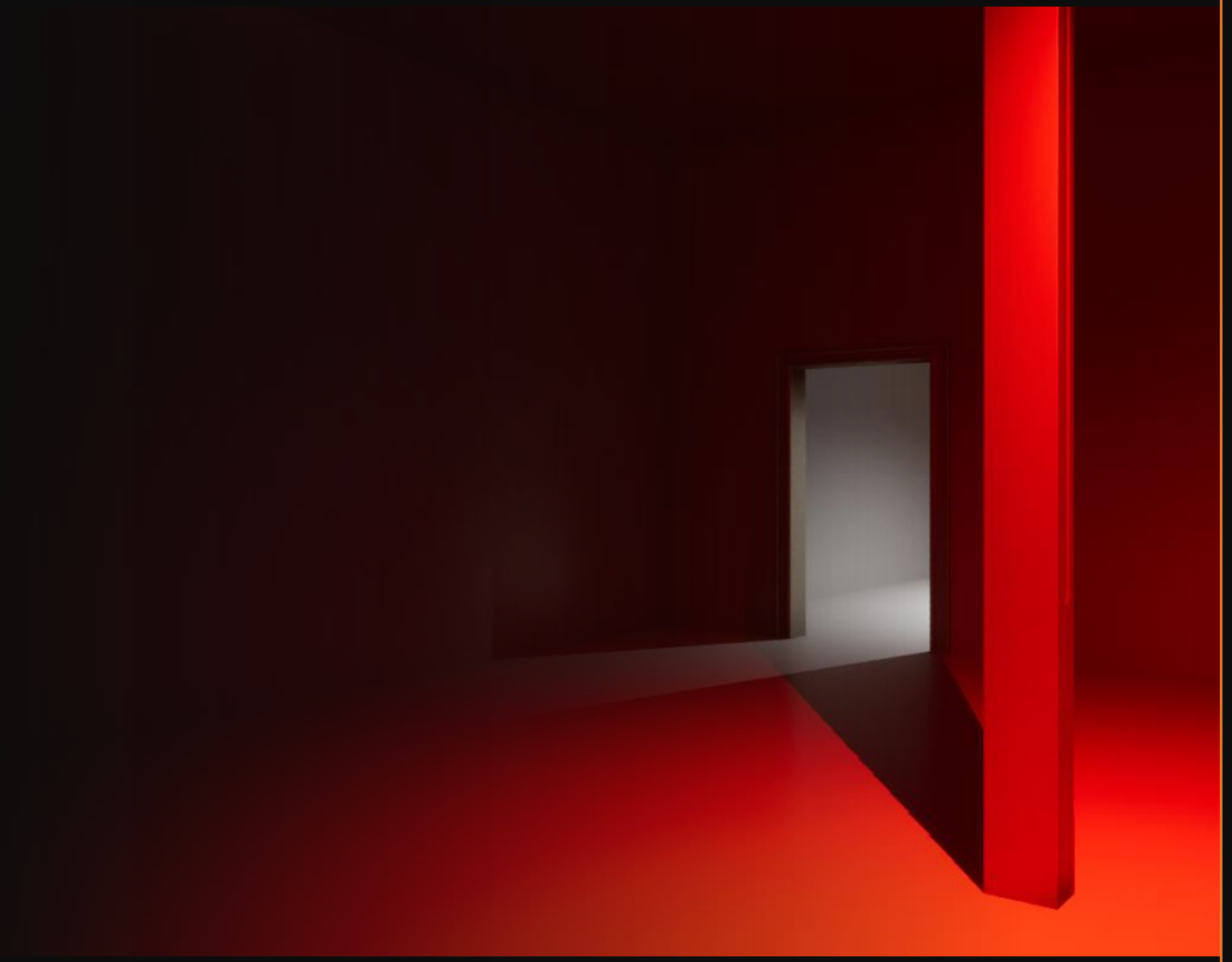
(Playdead, 2016)

Theory

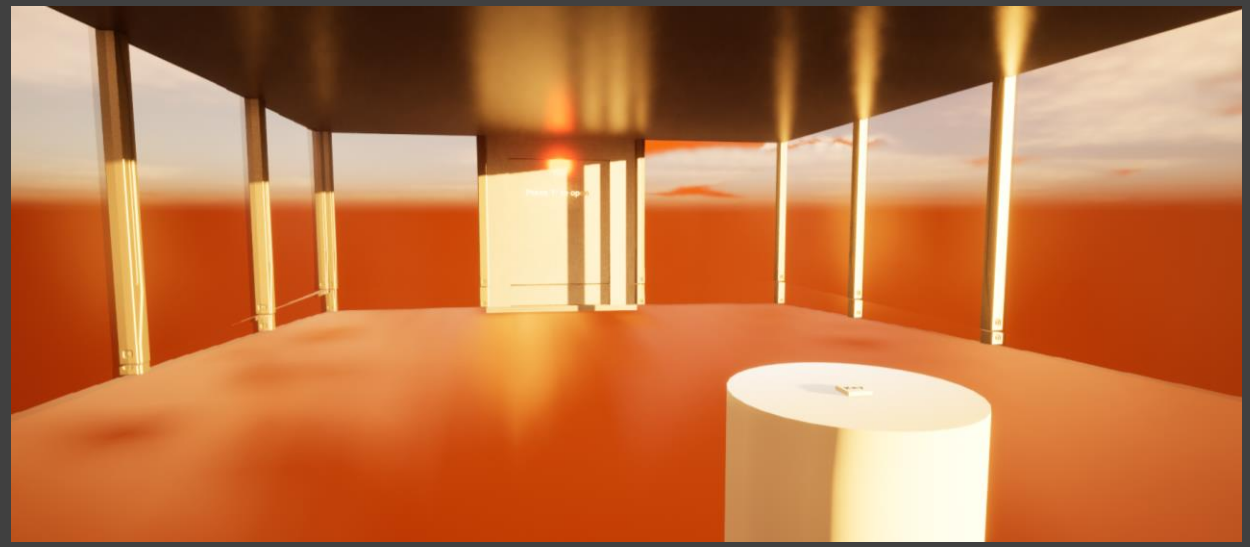
In designing the floors of my level with the chosen brief of phycology with a focus on phobias, there were a few architectural principles that I tried to bear in mind.

- Using level changes in the flooring to add variation and forcing the player to feel more exposed on the upper leverages. “One step between floor levels is rarely sufficient to create to meaningful differentiation of space” (Frederick, 2007, p. 63). Taking this into consideration I used a minimum of 3 steps per stair.
- Environmental storytelling. Putting myself in the shoes of the player, thinking about which paths they’ll take and how to tell a story as they progress. “Architecture is a vehicle for the telling of stories, a canvas for relaying societal myths, a stage for the theatre of everyday life” (Frederick, 2007, p. 84). Applying this to my level in a linear flow.
- When designing the basic assets for my game, I first had to consider the environment around them so that everything fit and flowed together. “Always design a thing by considering it in its next larger context” (Frederick, 2007, p. 92). This was important when deciding the placement of the elevators. Each had to be at both ends of the room meaning the architectural flow had to lead to the player towards them.

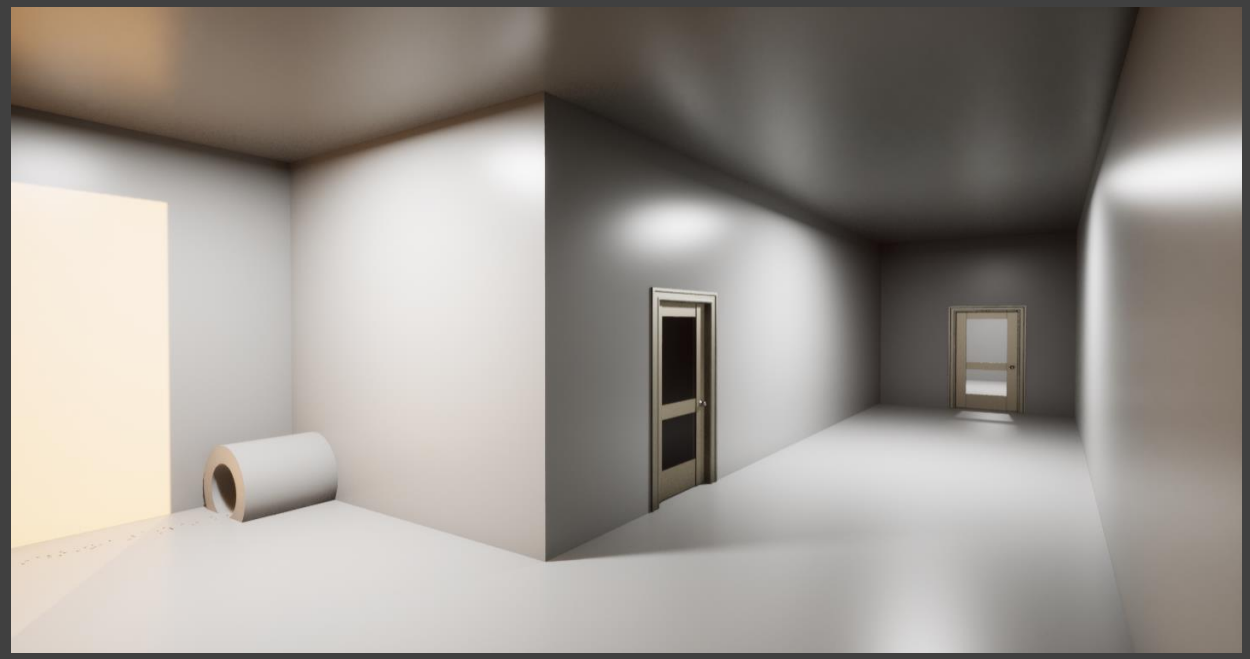
As the screen capture from my level shows. With limited time and resources, I had to make my level as efficient as possible. In creating horror, an effective way of doing this is with use of lighting, colour and narrow space – the fear of the unknown. “Even when there is no danger within dark corners of caves or gamespaces, the psychological effect of the unknown cannot be ignored. In games, architecture, and media, darkness is just one way that designers build the perception of negative space” (Kremers, 2009, p. 96). The intentions I set for my level were for it to be a short but sweet experience - this meant that I had to utilise the small scope that I had. Throughout my level I used only white and red lighting. White light was used neutrally which encouraged players to move through spaces and red light was used to evoke a sense of danger. “These associations carry over to games: one typically sees red or green health items, due to these colors’ associations with blood, medicine, or growth. Blue is the colour of magic or mana in many games, having a mystical association. Green is also used in many contexts of alien creatures or monsters thanks to associations with nuclear materials or swamps. Level designers would be wise to pay attention to these and other colour associations when planning their game environments” (Totten, 2019, p. 232). I have taken this theory and applied it with use of shadows.



Dark, moody lighting is something that is consistent in my level to really push the horror narrative. Since the bottom floor is intended to represent fear of heights, I designed an open plan room with the surrounding walls and floors made from glass. However, in this final floor there is an atmospheric shift. I created a beautiful sunset which casts shadows which is pleasing on the eye. The room is bright and induces the player into a sense of false hope. It follows the same structure as the other levels however this time the elevator key prompt reads “interact to escape”. As the player enters the elevator, there is a short delay - perhaps a glitch? No, the player then plumets downwards and the game ends.

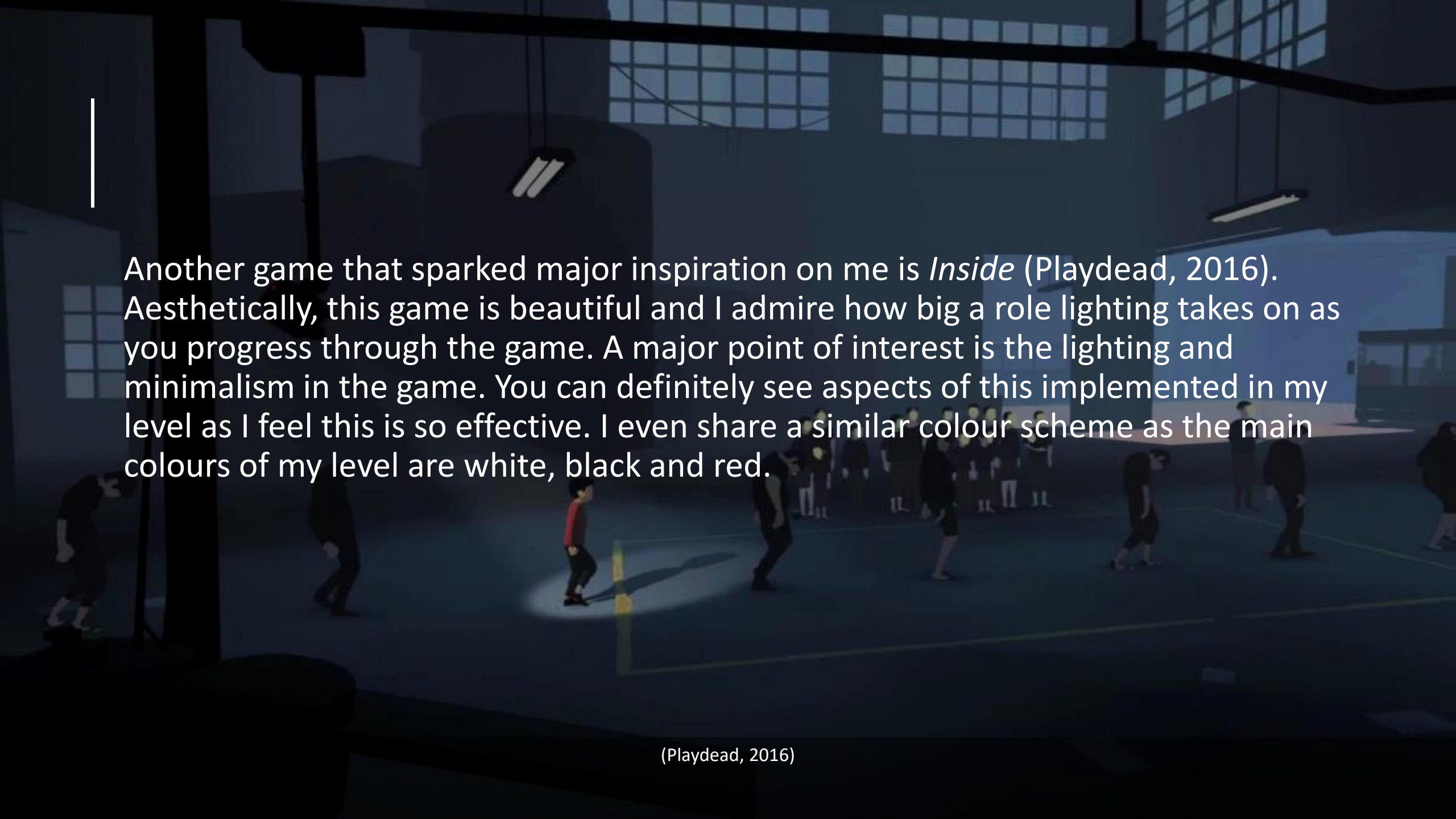


I kept the design of the levels minimalist, mostly blank walls and flooring. Also only including architecture that was necessary so the player wouldn’t waste time trying to interact with things that served no purpose. This was a personal design choice as it can somethings frustrate me in games when it’s not so clear what is interactable and what isn’t. It wastes time and causes distress in the player so I shifted my focus to lighting. “Shade is an important element of many video games, as its ability to represent both sacred and malevolent spaces allows it to create atmospheric ambiguity—a condition where the player is unsure of whether a space is safe or unsafe due to a combination of friendly, unfriendly, and ambiguous spatial indicators“ (Totten, 2019, p. 280). Since my game is to be short and sweet, this worked out well.



Inspiration from other games

Iron Lung analysis (David Szymanski, 2022). As an indie game developer done an incredible job at his 2022 release of “Iron Lung”. After careful analysis of this game, I have taken notes of what I think worked well in the game to make it a great horror experience. As a horror fanatic myself there is not a lot that will shake me to my core and this game done that for me. I thought the lack of audio was genius as with a continuation of silence there is absolutely no sign of a scare coming which I felt created a consistent tension. Iron Lung uses a low poly art style which builds a sense of nostalgia. “That's where Iron Lung sat following my trip to a Loch Ness museum in 2019, where a random bit of narration got me thinking about the idea of being underwater taking fuzzy pictures of some unseen creature” (David Szymasnki, 2022). This game also hits home for me as it was inspired here in Scotland by the infamous Loch Ness Monster.

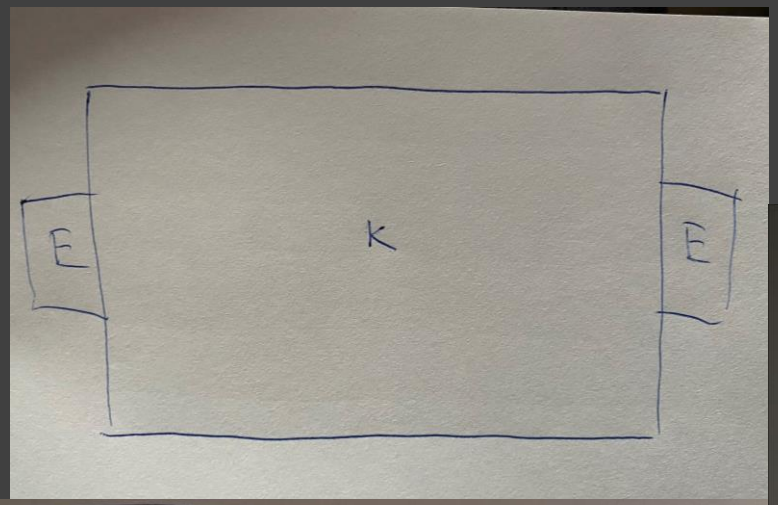


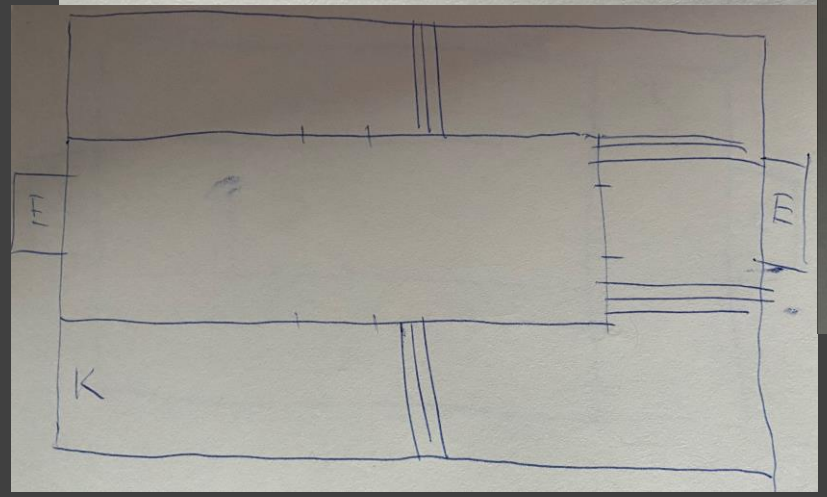
Another game that sparked major inspiration on me is *Inside* (Playdead, 2016). Aesthetically, this game is beautiful and I admire how big a role lighting takes on as you progress through the game. A major point of interest is the lighting and minimalism in the game. You can definitely see aspects of this implemented in my level as I feel this is so effective. I even share a similar colour scheme as the main colours of my level are white, black and red.

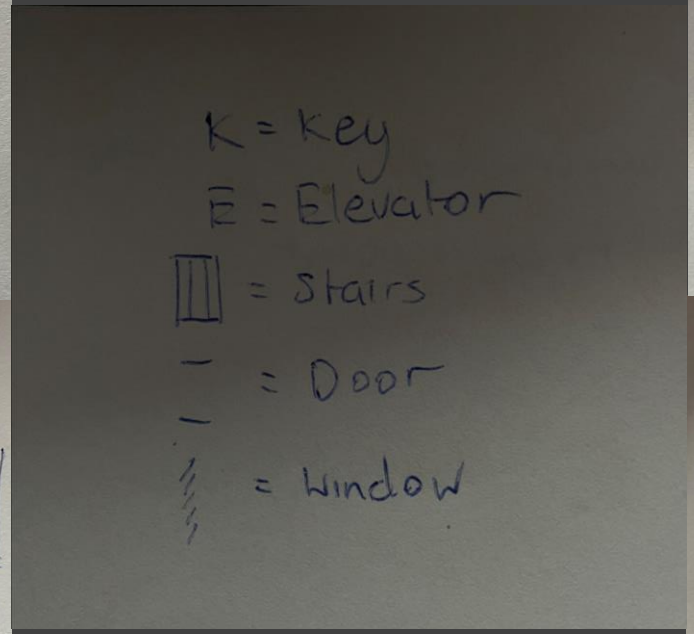
(Playdead, 2016)

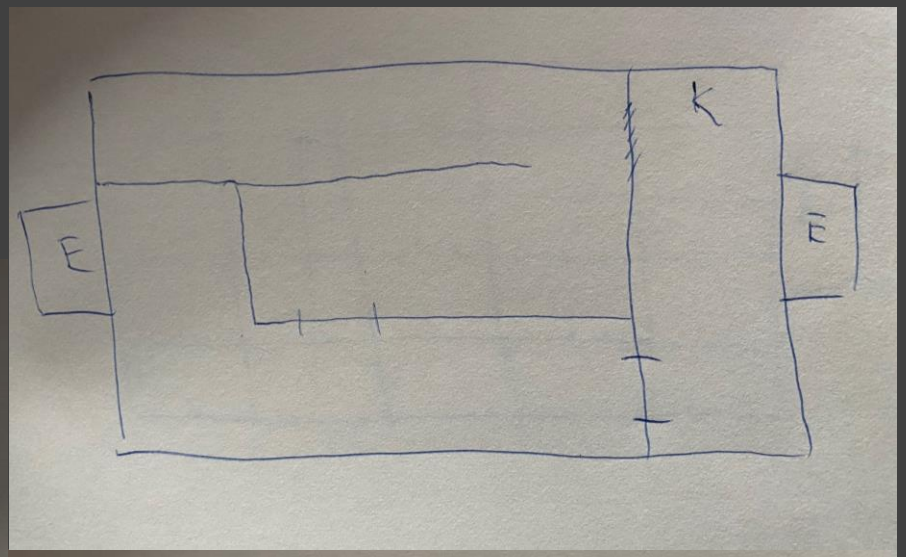
Planning and Previsualization

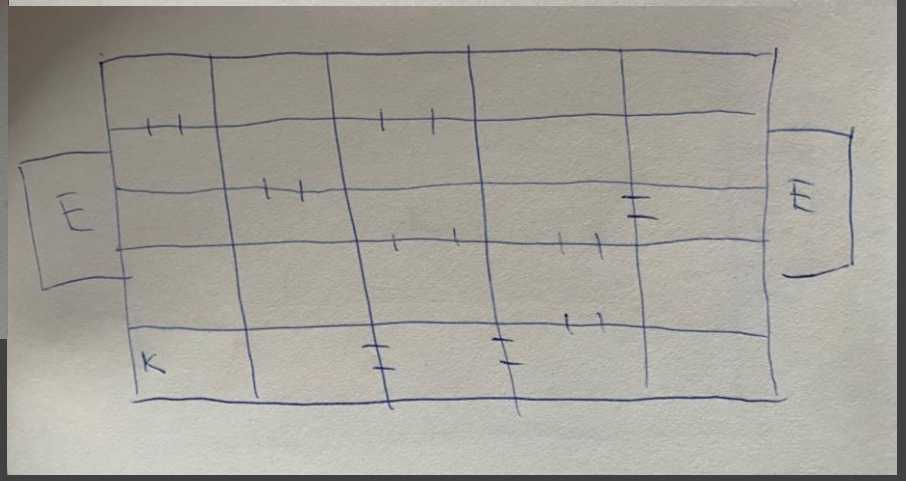
Taking into account all of my architectural research, I began sketching up the flow of my levels.





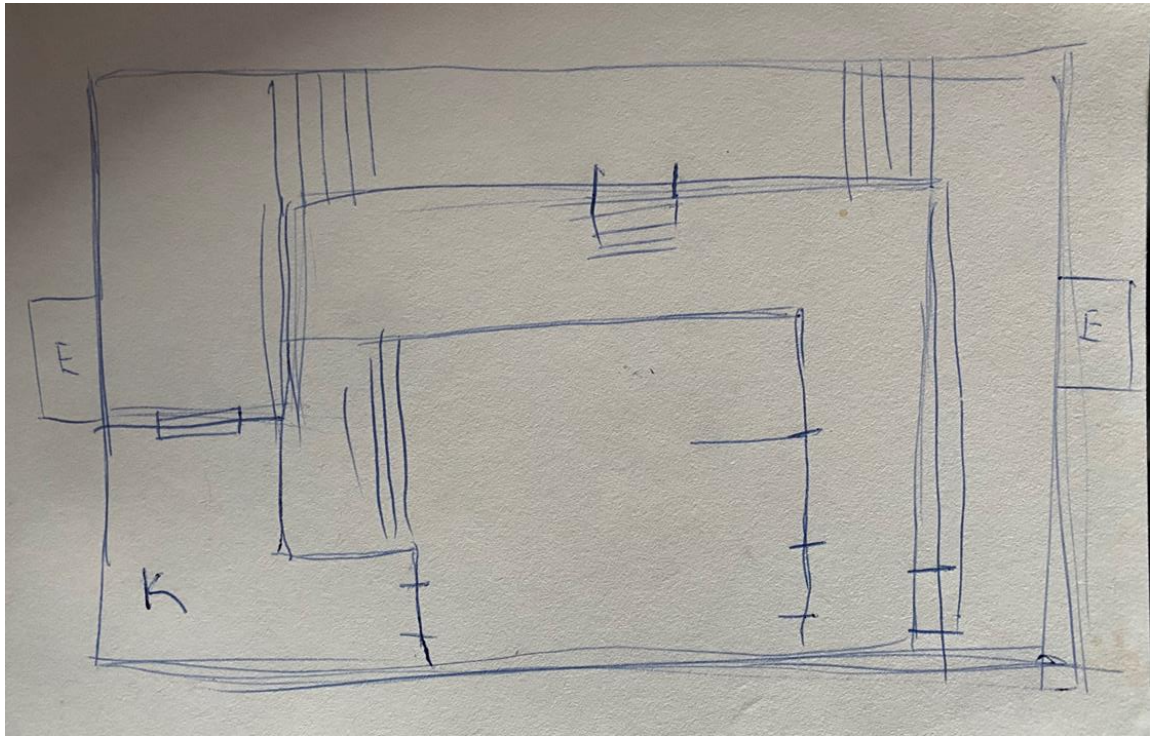




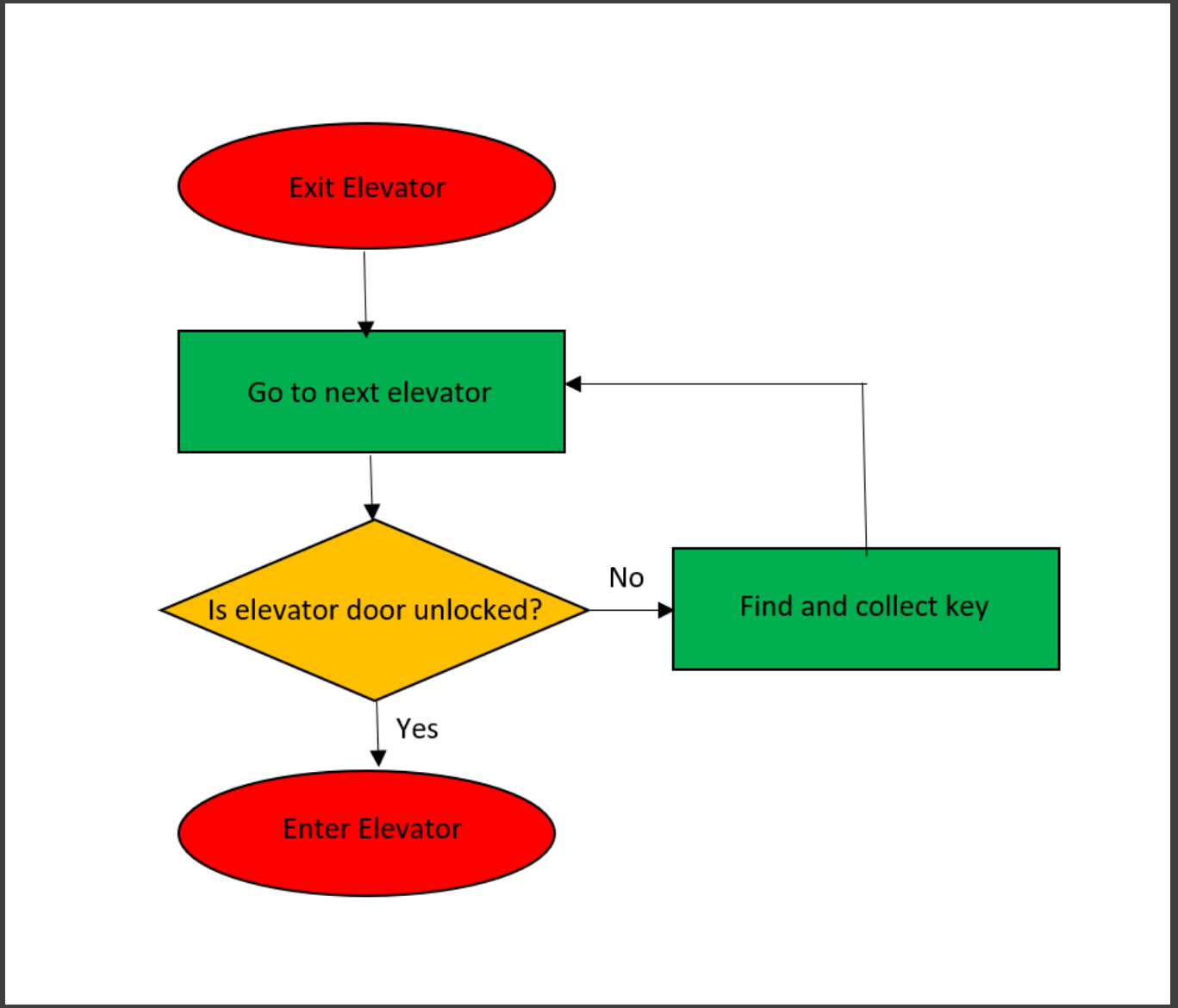


When implementing this into game, there was a lot of back and forth to make sure I was happy with the design. You can see the final top-down layout in the image on the left where I included slanted walls to guide the player and split the centre room into two. “As a game designer, a large part of your role is to keep your concentration focused on the player experience and not allow yourself to be distracted by the other concerns of production” (Fullerton, 2018, p. 3). During implementing, all my tweaks were based off what would be best suited for the player.



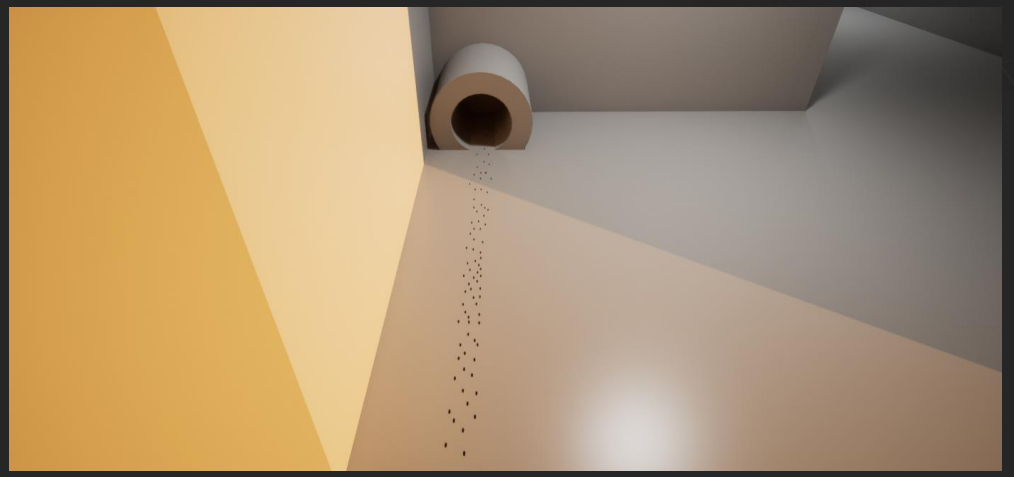


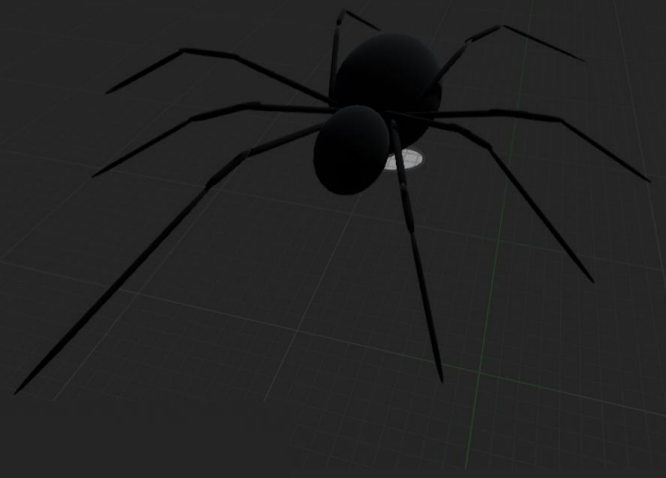
Flowchart of level



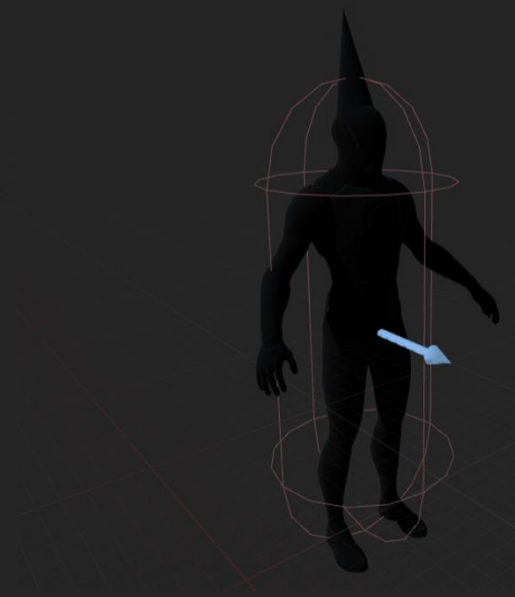
Design

Since I only had access to the starter content on UE5 this meant that I was very restricted as to what assets I could include in my game. I could've used maya to model and texture my own assets however this would've taken a while and I would not have been graded for it. Instead, I opted to utilize the shapes unreal had to offer and by manipulating these I managed to make some great horror features for my level. Even though these assets weren't animated I still found them to be very effective.



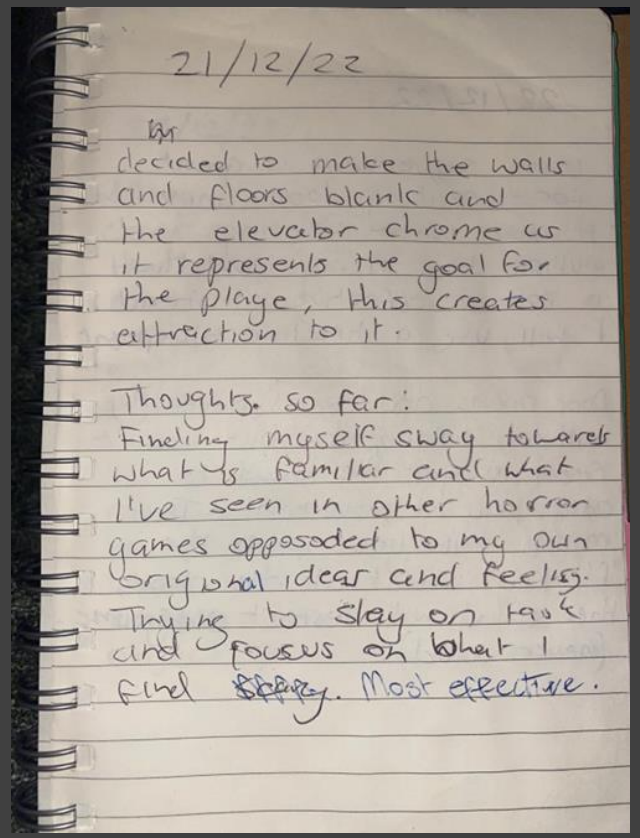






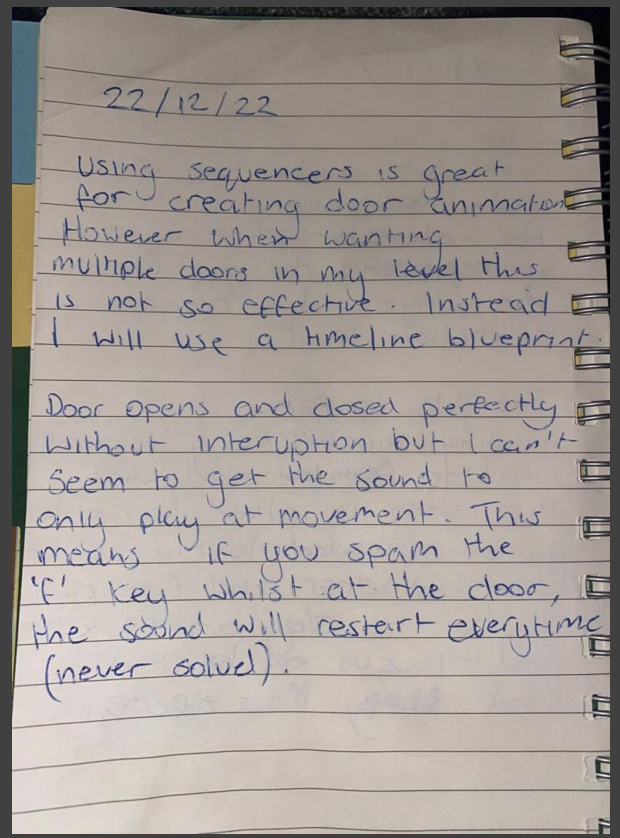
Development and testing

Throughout my development process I began creating a sort of diary where I would write my thoughts, challenges, progress and feedback with the date. ”The game designer must look at the world of games through the players eyes”(Fullerton, 2018, p. 3). This was good to refer to so that I was always staying on track.


21/12/22

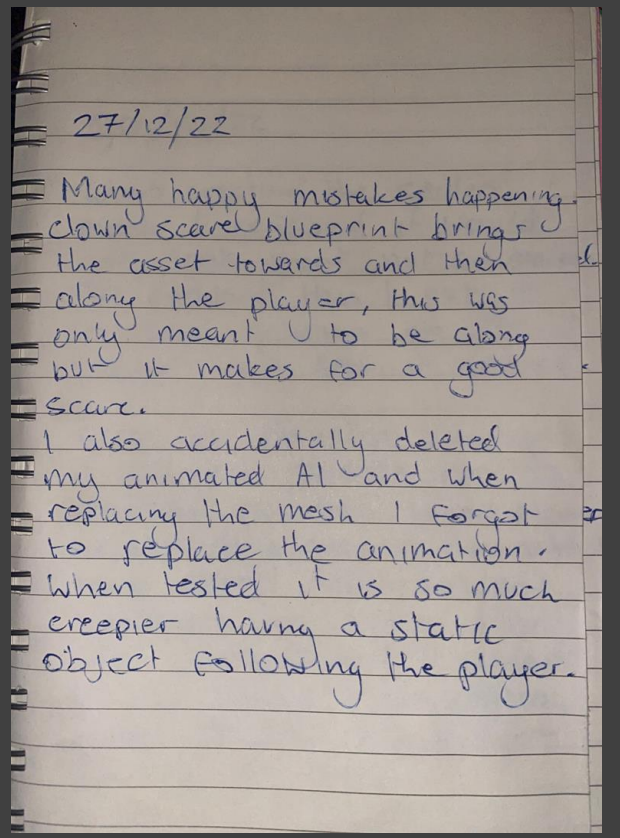
decided to make the walls and floors blank and the elevator chrome as it represents the goal for the playe, this creates attraction to it.

Thoughts so far:
Finding myself sway towards what is familar and what I've seen in other horror games opposoded to my own original idear and feeling. Trying to stay on task and focuss on what I find ~~Scary~~. Most effective.


22/12/22

Using sequencers is great for creating door animation However when wanting multiple doors in my level this is not so effective. Instead I will use a timeline blueprint.

Door opens and closed perfectly without interuption but I can't seem to get the sound to only play at movement. This means if you spam the 'f' key whilst at the door, the sound will restart everytime (never solved).


27/12/22

Many happy mistakes happening. clown scared blueprint brings the asset towards and then along the player, this was only meant to be along but it makes for a good scare.
I also accidentally deleted my animated AI and when replacing the mesh I forgot to replace the animation. When tested it is so much creepier having a static object following the player.

30/12/22

When creating the spider mesh I realised it would not look great not animated. To combat this I put it in low lighting so the player can see it emerge.

Error in elevator blueprint it will not reverse into its starting position when player exits. This means the next two floors down will get blocked by open door. To combat this I added a 20s delay then destroy actor to give the player plenty of time.

3/1/23

Found a downloadable texture online for my trypophobia level. When implementing some walls overlap and create a glitching texture. (never solved)

5/1/23

Somewhere along the way of me testing out blueprints, I have created a bug with the first person arms. When the player picks up the gun, arms were not visable, but it was still functional. It would be confusing to the player to keep this in the game so I disregarded it.

8/1/23

I originally made lighting warm White but Once having some friends test for me, I recieved feedback that cool White would be best suited for a horror game of my type so I changed them.

In recieving feedback I was also told that some areas were too dark that they felt confused and disoriented.

I never adding skylight as a feature since my game was indoors. However I was informed it made the last floor look bad as it was all glass. I created a beutiful Sunset.

9/1/23

When adding finishing touches to my level I felt there was something missing in my second to last floor. A threat. Although in my research I said I would not be including background ambience to my level, I did to this ~~level~~ floor. This was a big improvement.

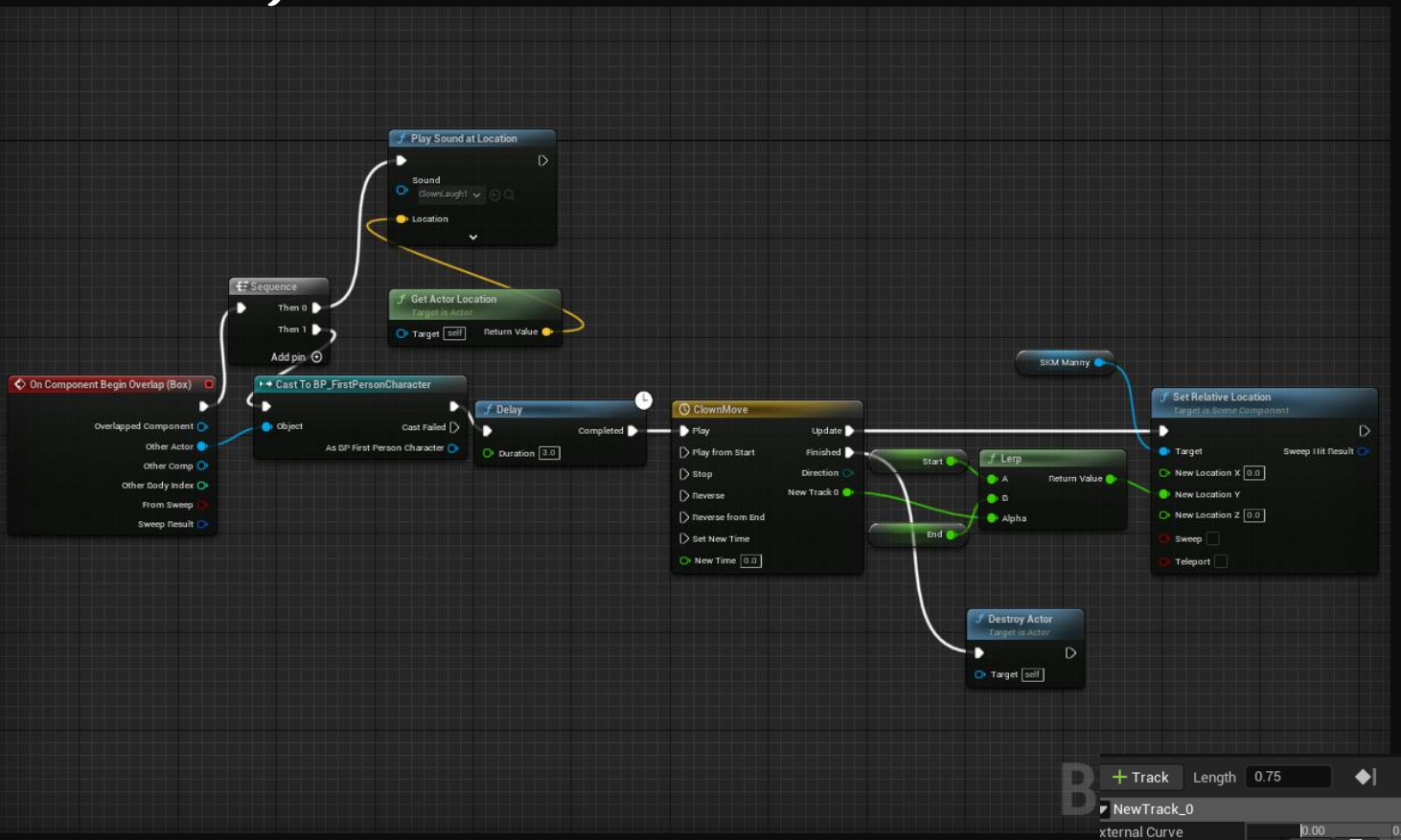
Development Renders



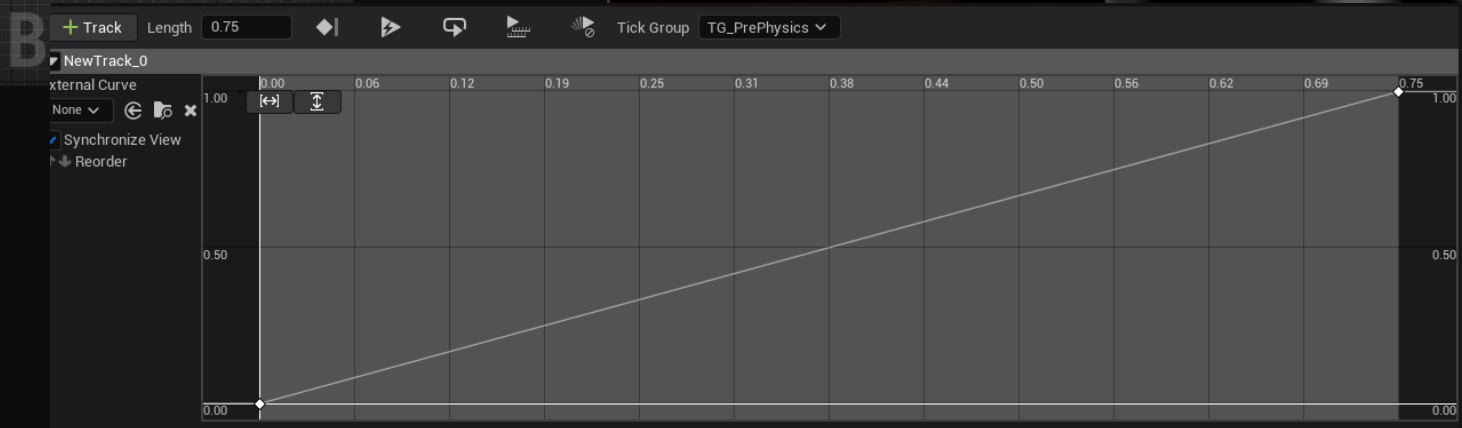




Blueprints and annotations



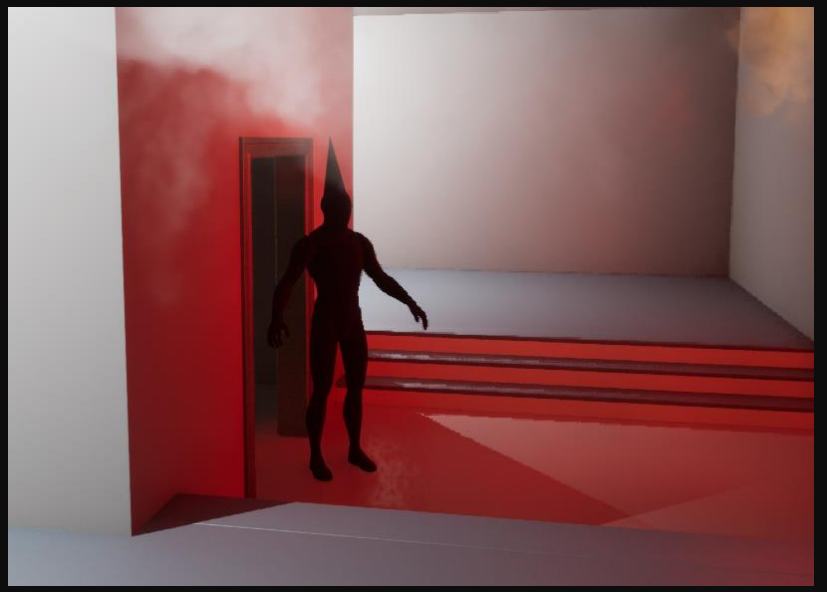


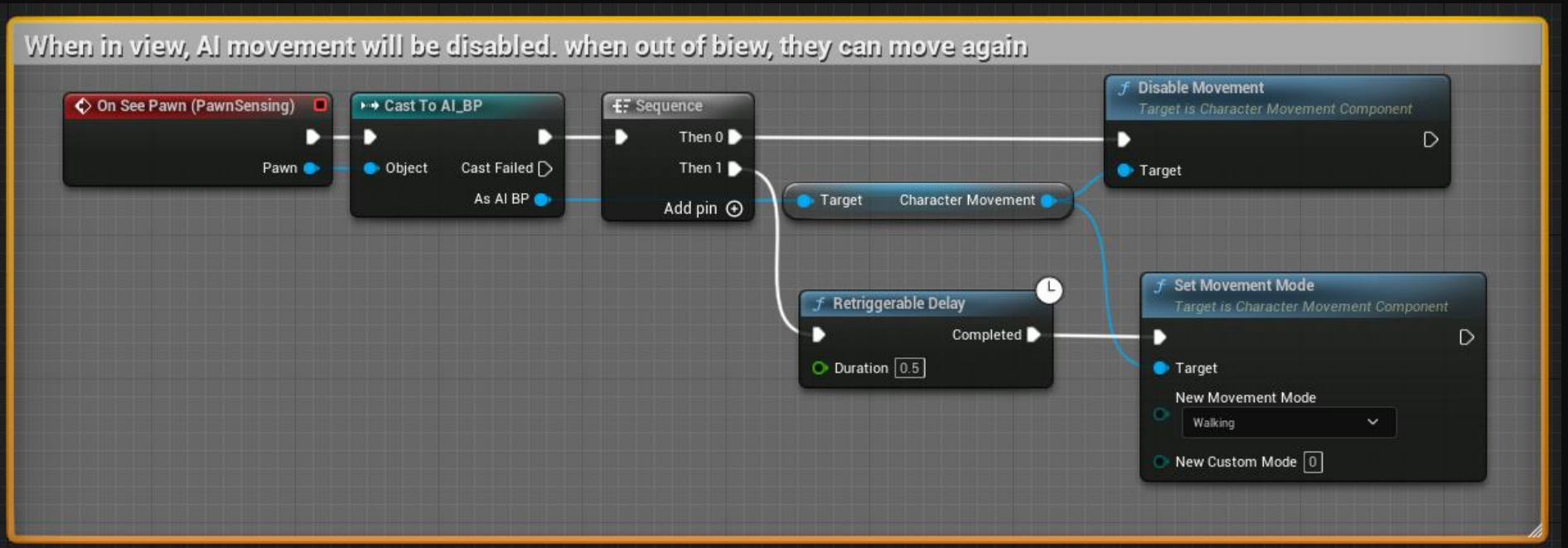


Created a timeline with two points, point A and point B. A with a value of 0 and time 0s and B with a value of 1 at time 0.75s. I then gave value B an end coordinate at the point where player would be standing to give a jump scare effect. It then moves off screen and destroys.

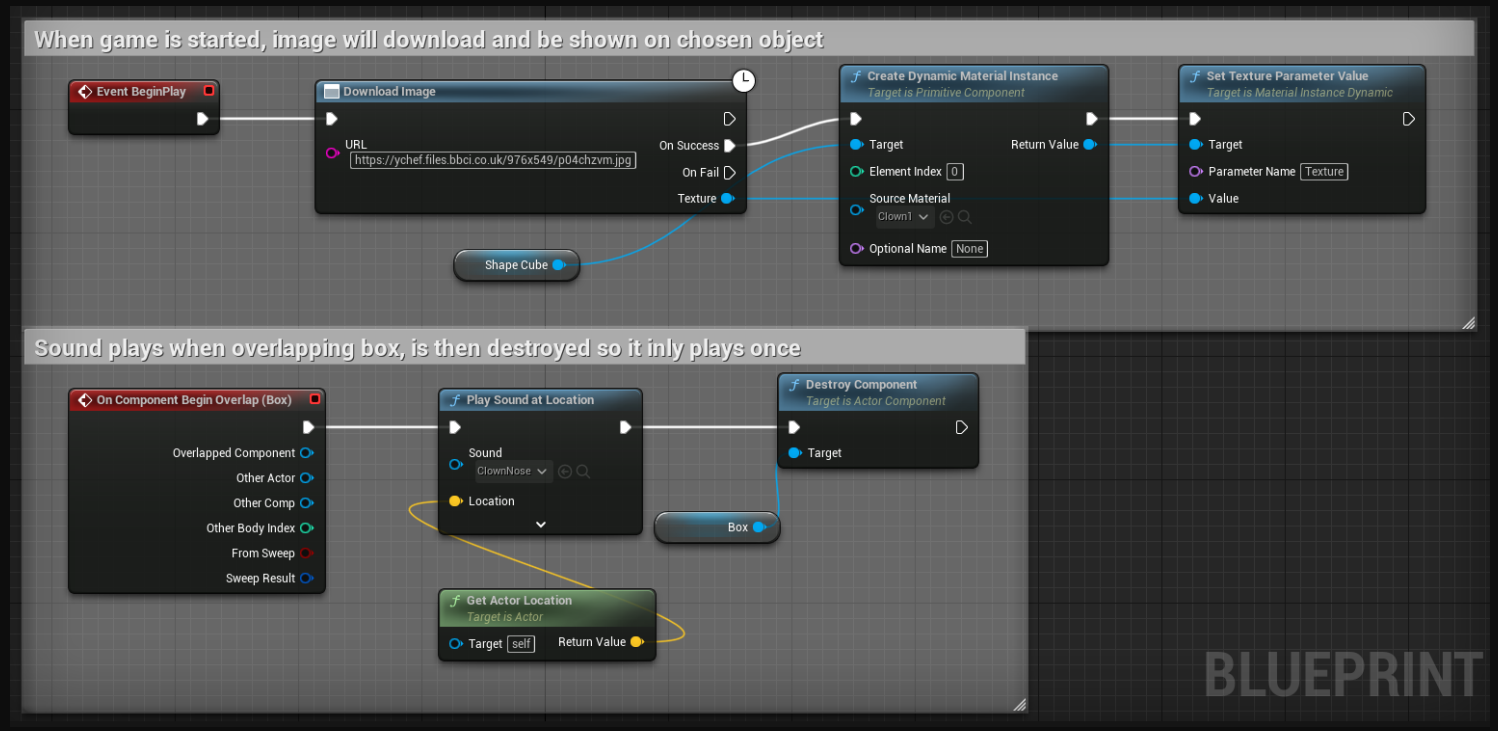






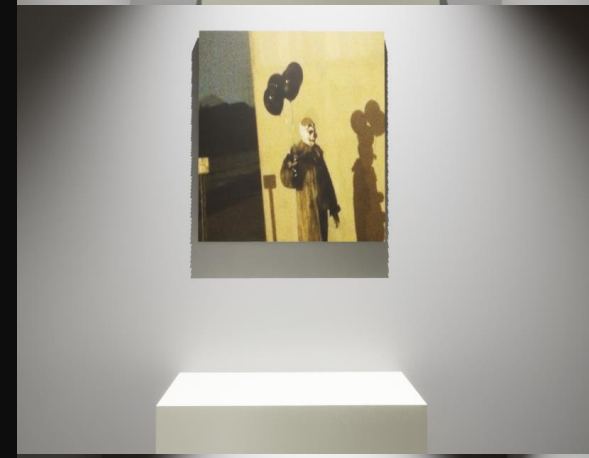


AI will stalk the player around the room. however if they are looked at they will freeze.

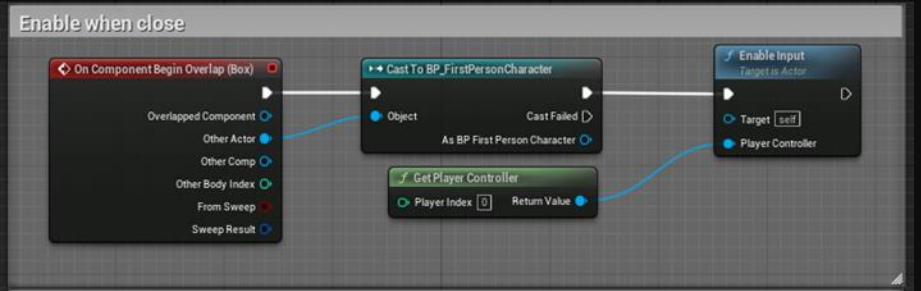


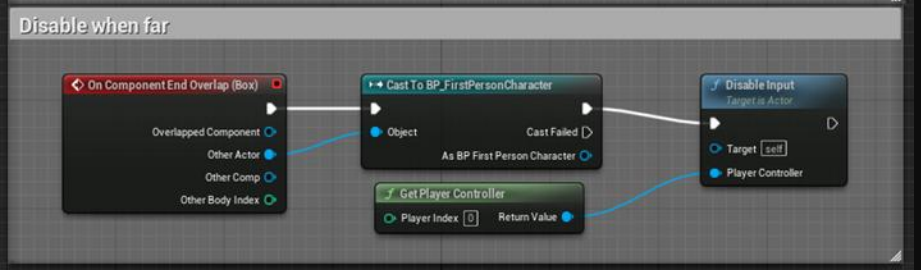
When game starts, images will download and be projected onto the shape using a source material. Sound will play when overlapping box placed in front. I used this 3 time with different images on the top level.

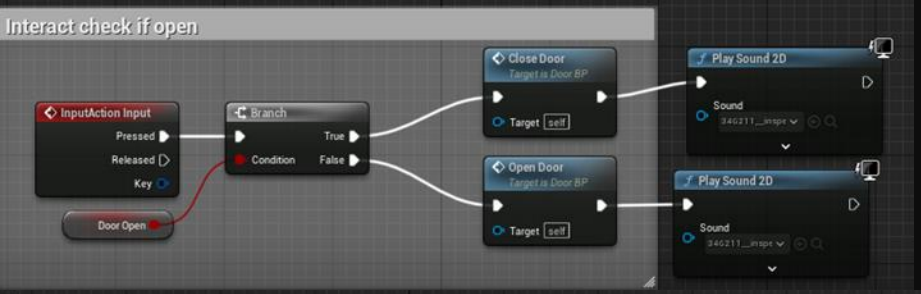


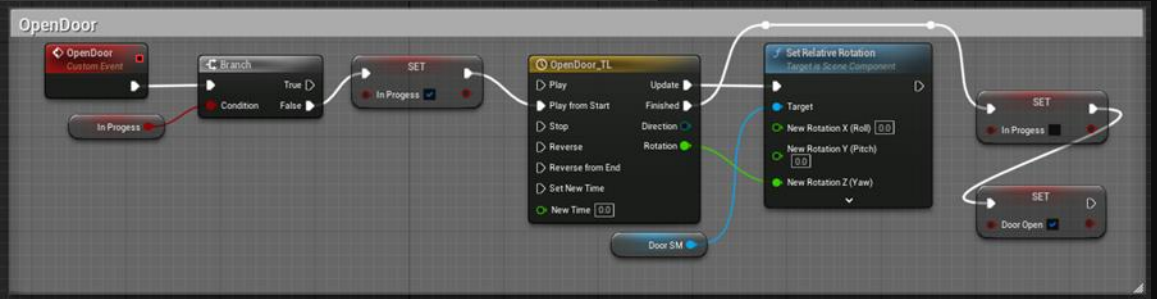


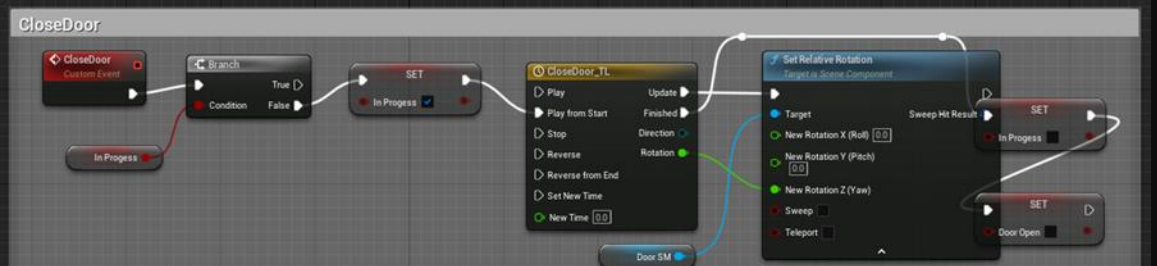










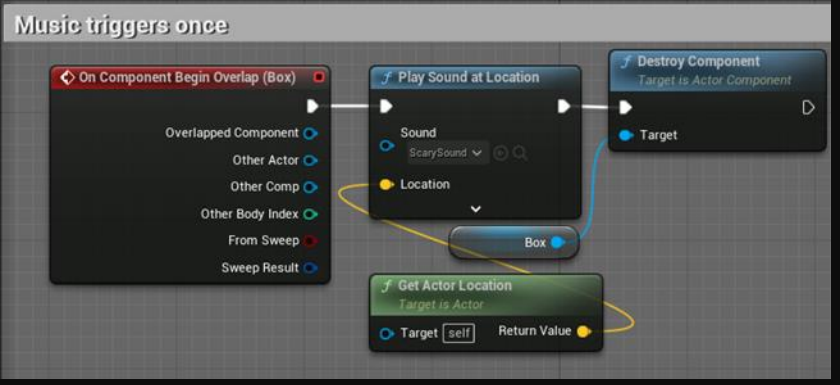


Input will be enabled when player is in close proximity and will be disabled when they are out of that proximity

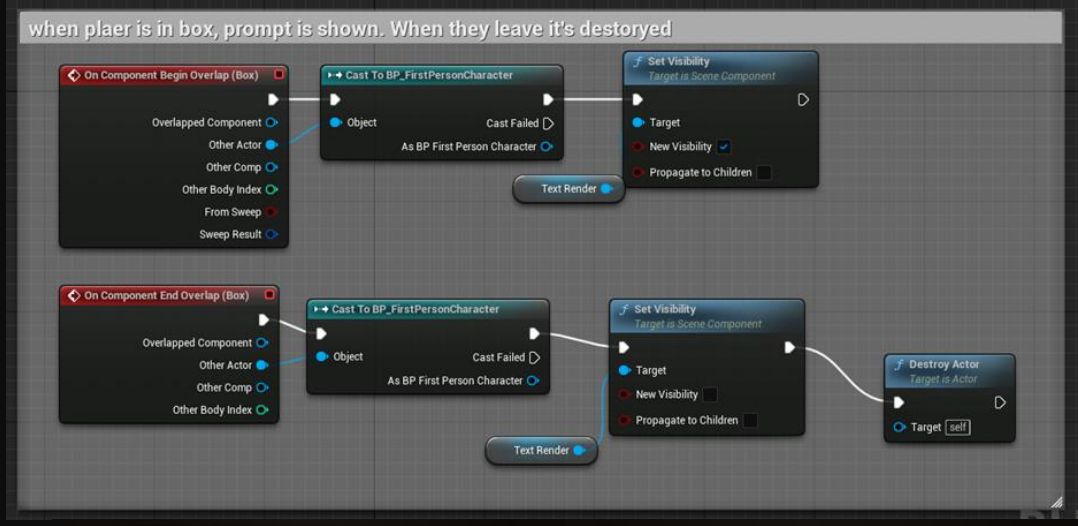


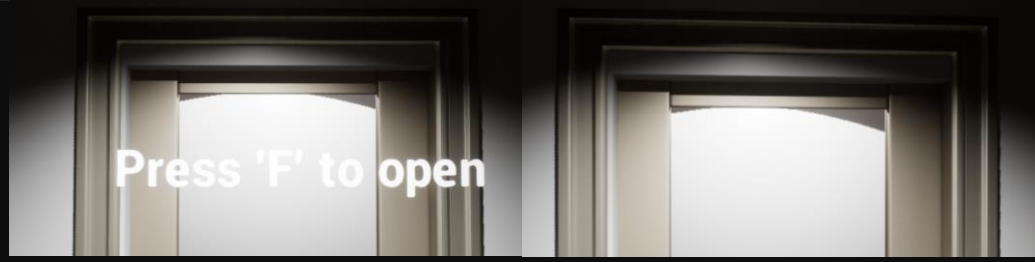


Using timeline again but this time setting the relative rotation. Created a Boolean to check if it is in progress of opening, if so pressing the interact key won't interrupt. Can only be interacted if closed or open.

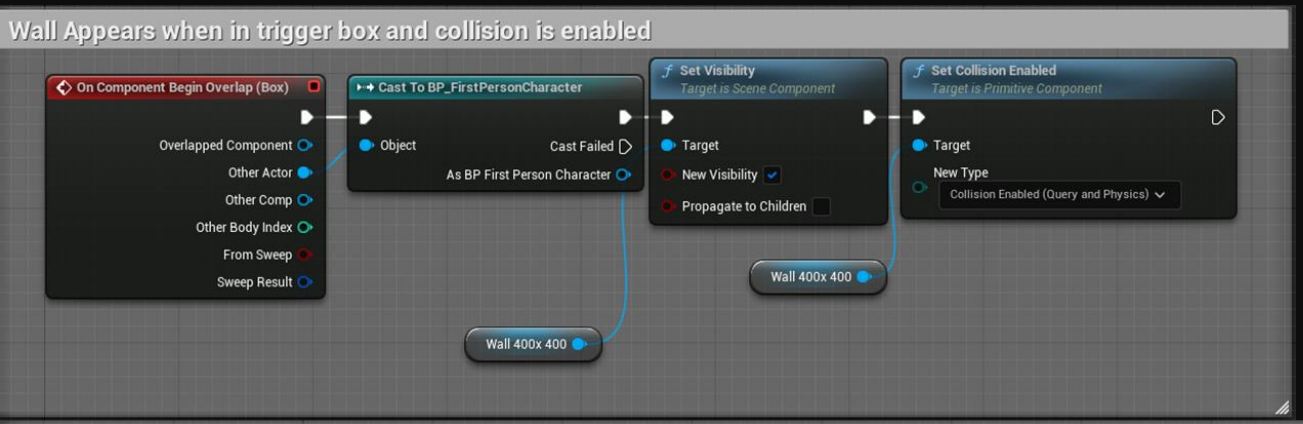


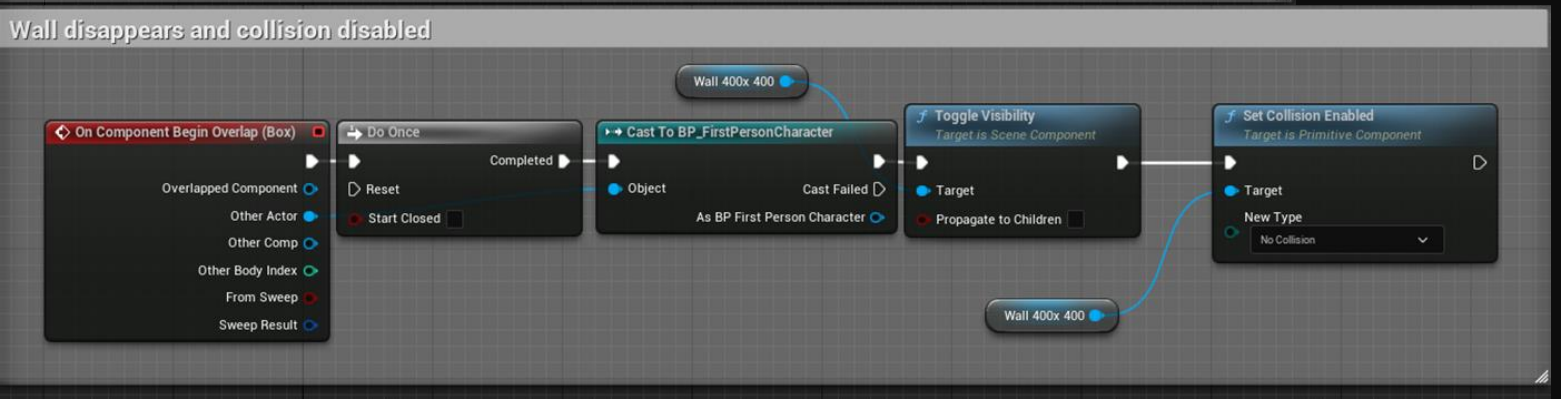
When in proximity, music will trigger. Destroy component so that it can only be triggered once.



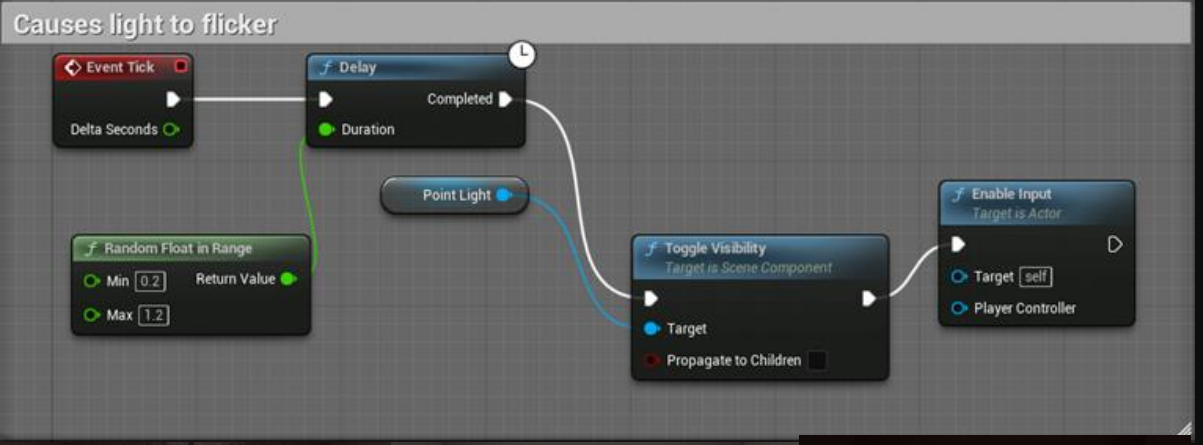


Prompt shown when in proximity, then destroyed when out of proximity. Good for teaching controls.





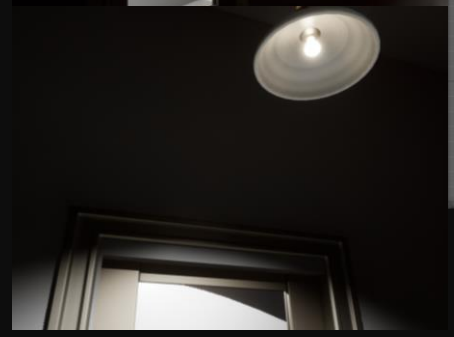
Walls will appear and disappear and collision will be set accordingly. Seen in my second to last floor and when leaving the elevators.

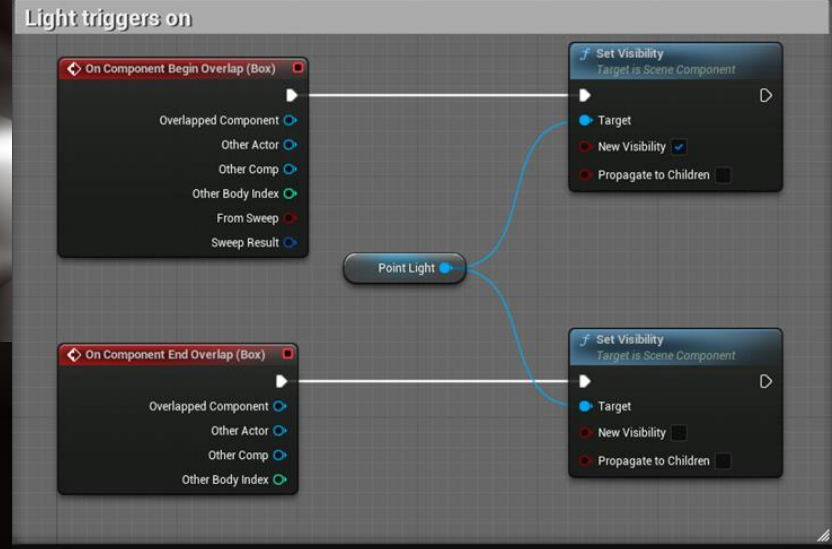




Light will randomly trigger off and on between 0.2s and 1.2s. Causes the appearance of flickering.





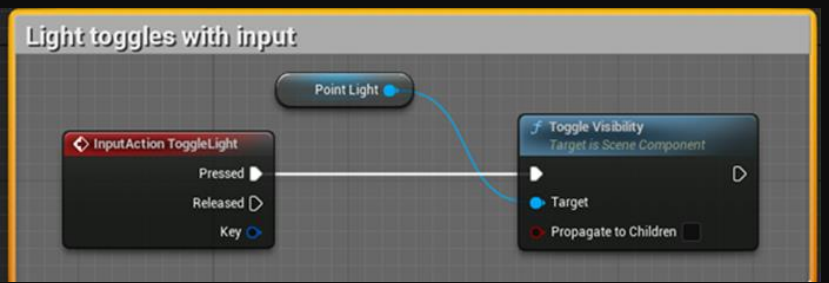


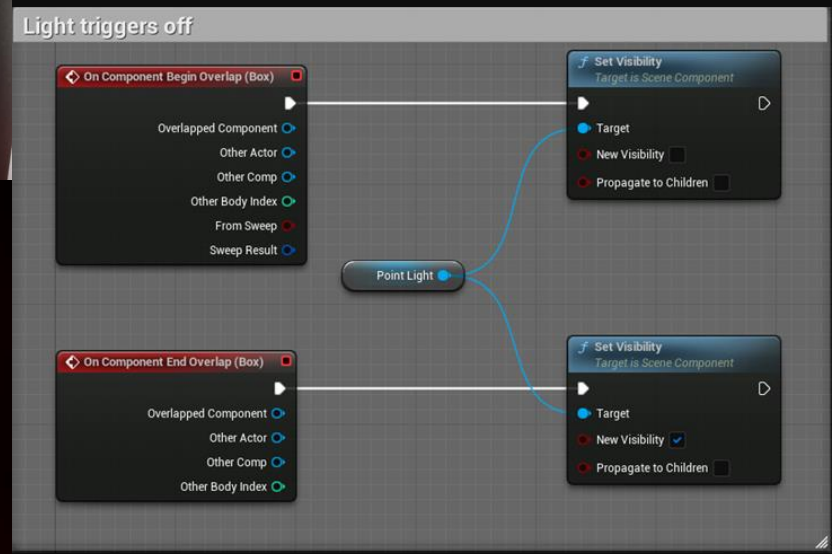
These do the opposite of each other. Triggering lights on and off when in proximity as seen in screenshots

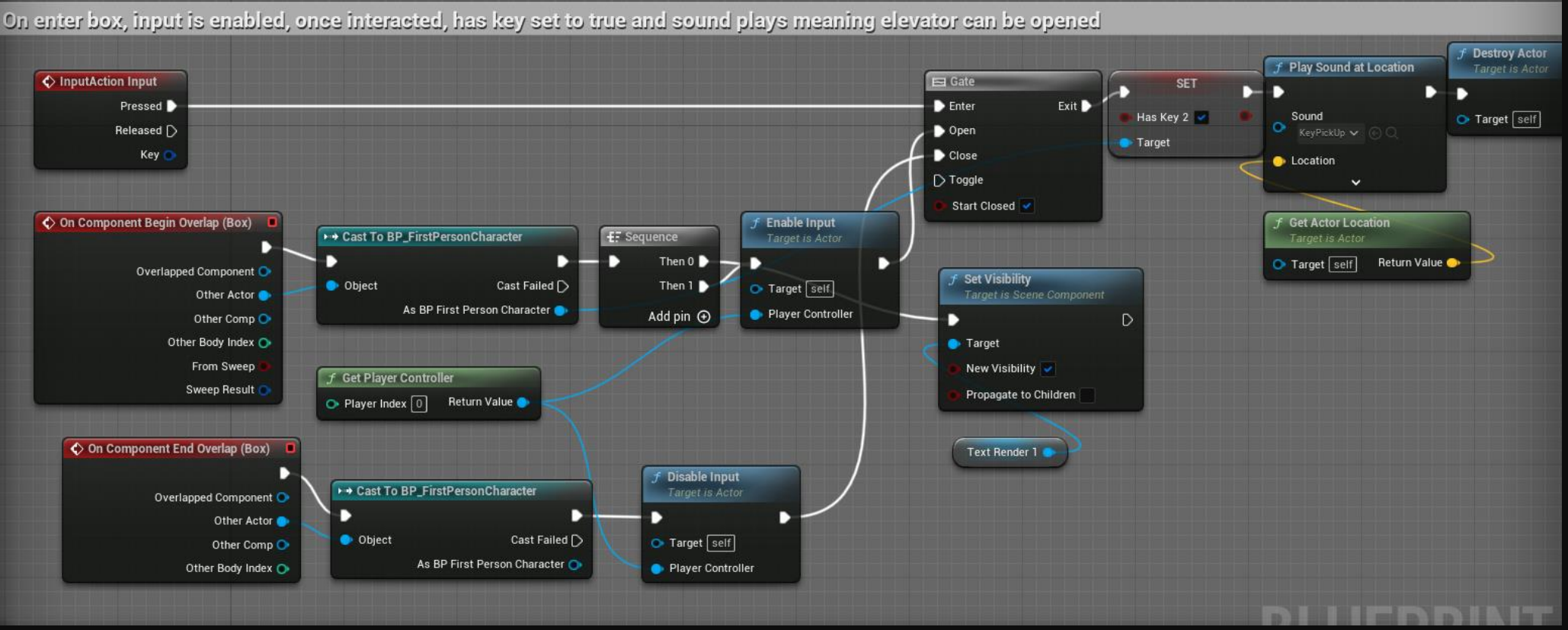




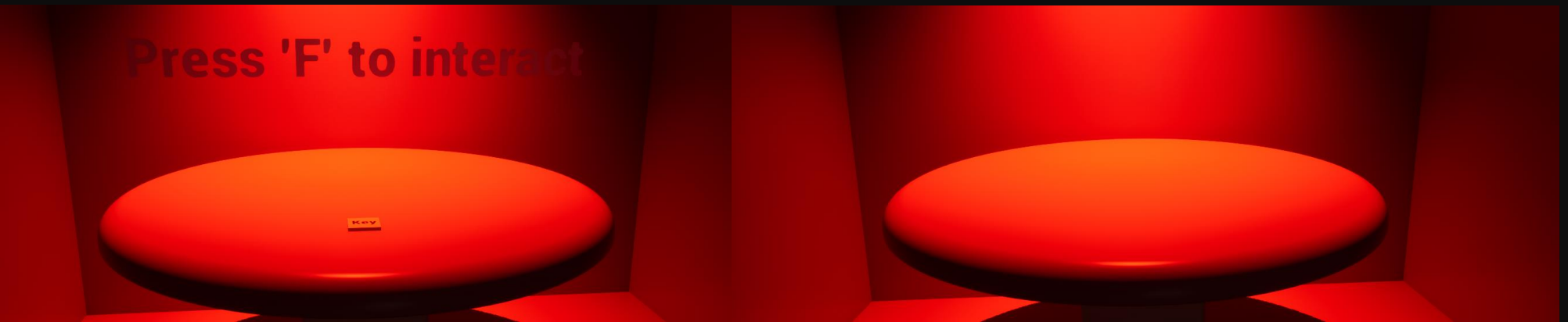
Light turns off and on with input



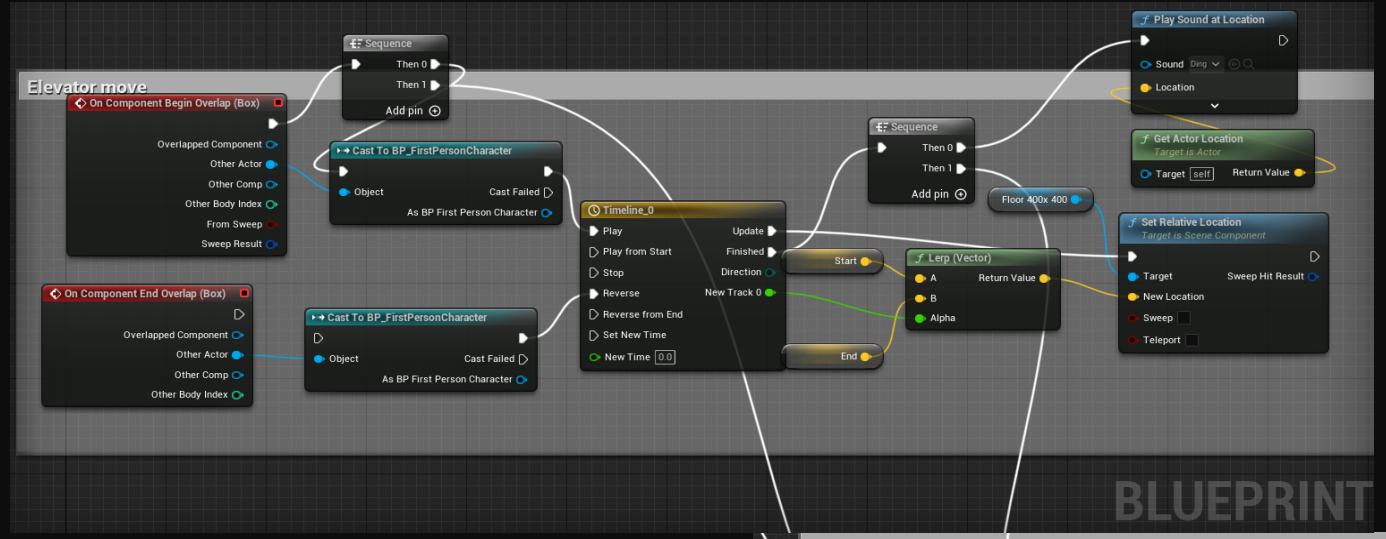




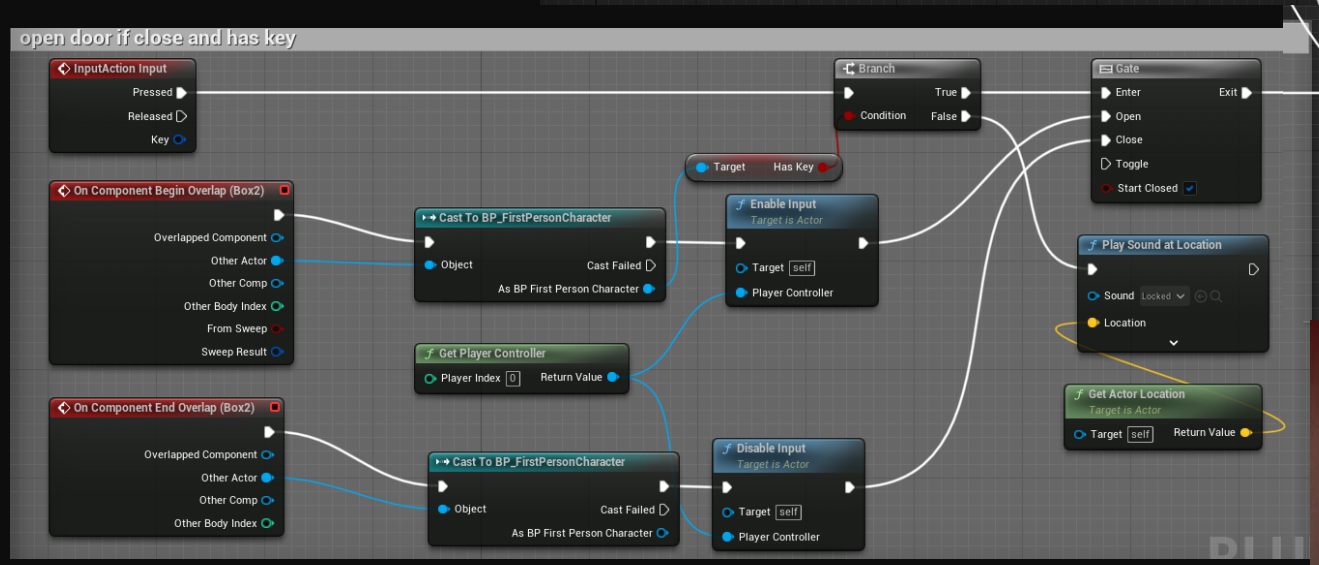
When in proximity, input is enabled. If ‘F’ button is pressed, item will be destroyed and has key will be set to true so that elevator can be opened.

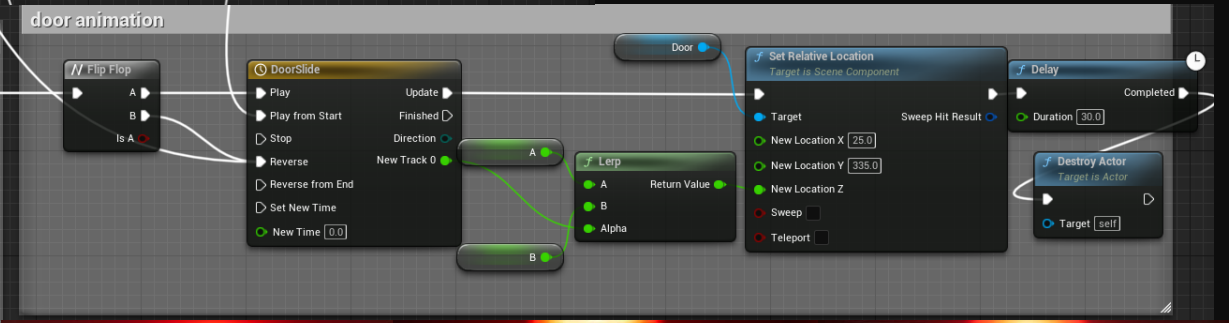


Using a timeline to move the elevator down a floor and added a sound effect to let the player know they have reached the next floor.



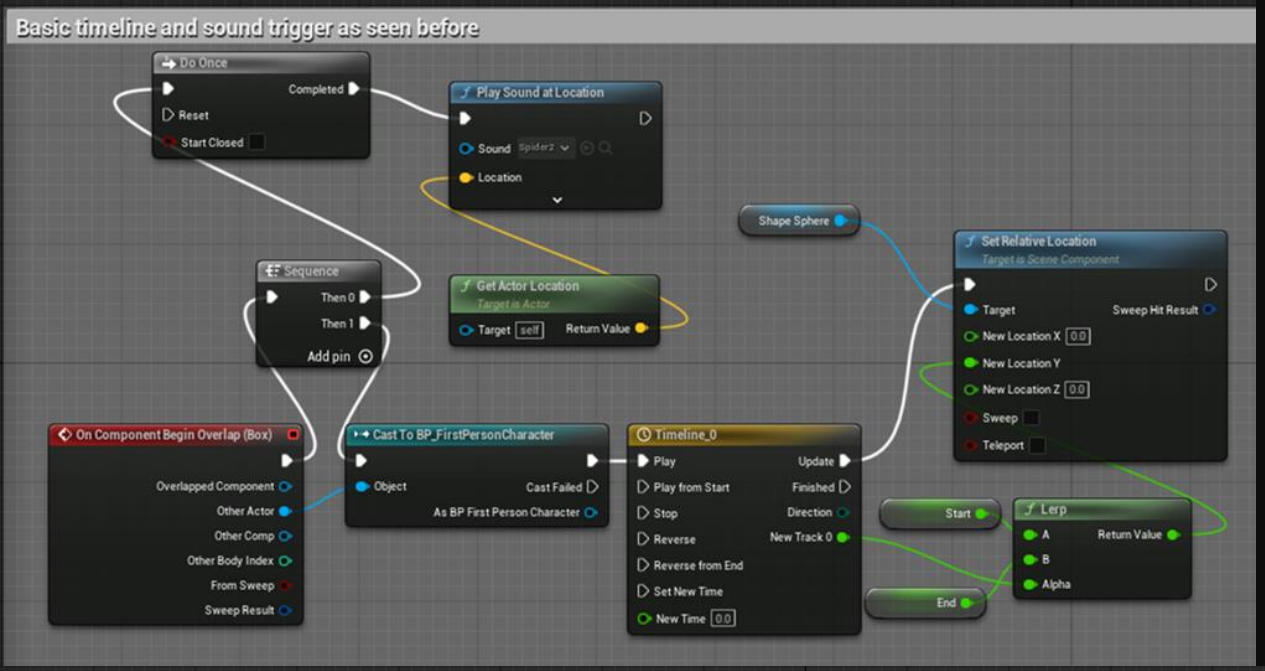
Another use of timeline to open the elevator door and close it again once player steps inside. I've put a delay and then destroy at the end so the elevator does not effect the other floors.





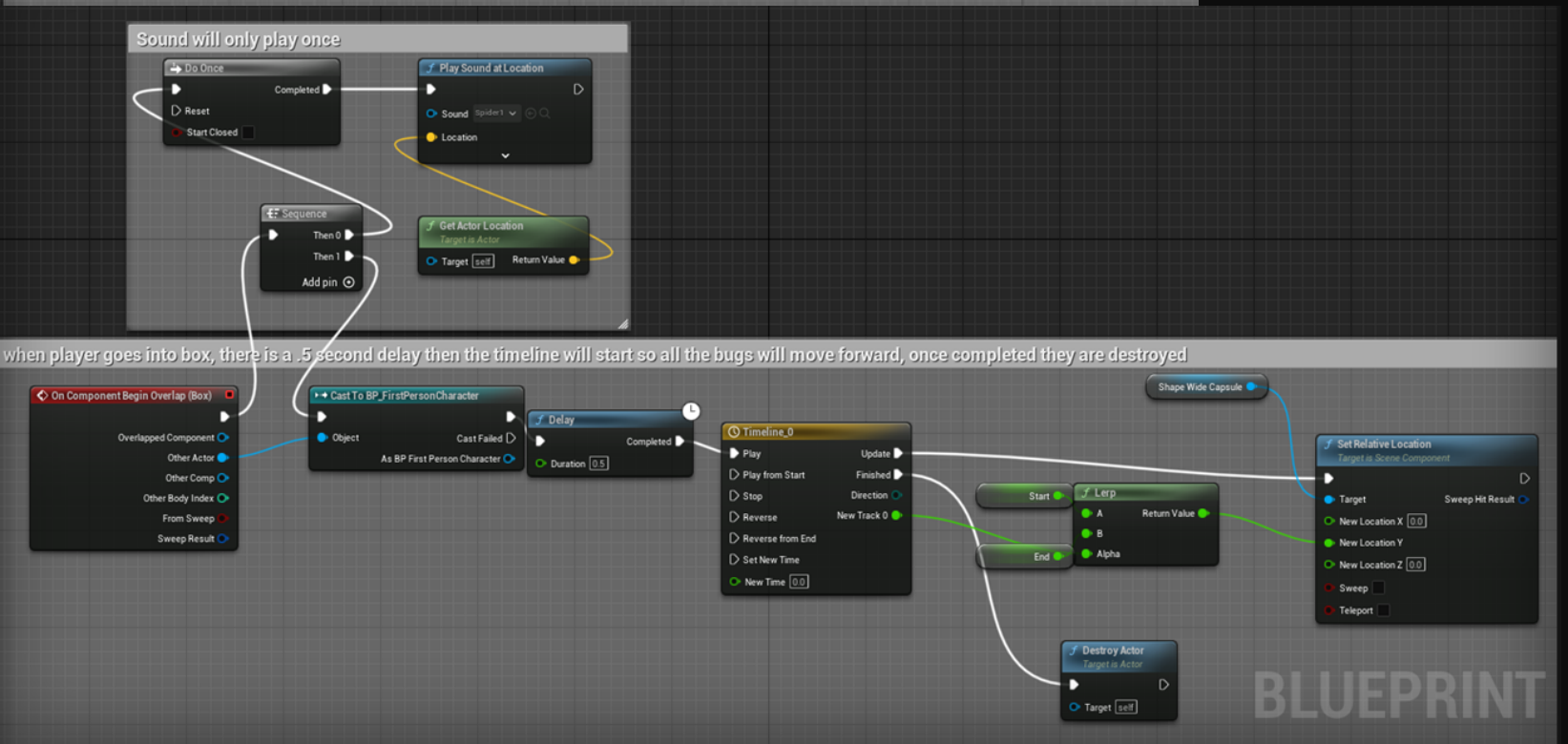


Checking if the player has they key. If they don't a lock sound will be player. If they do the door will then open.

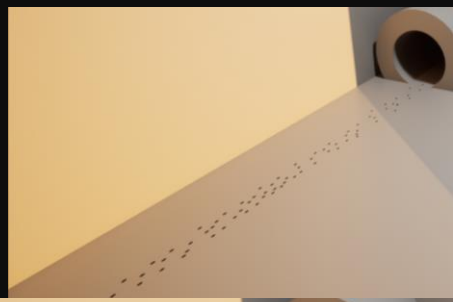




Timeline to move spider and sound activation.



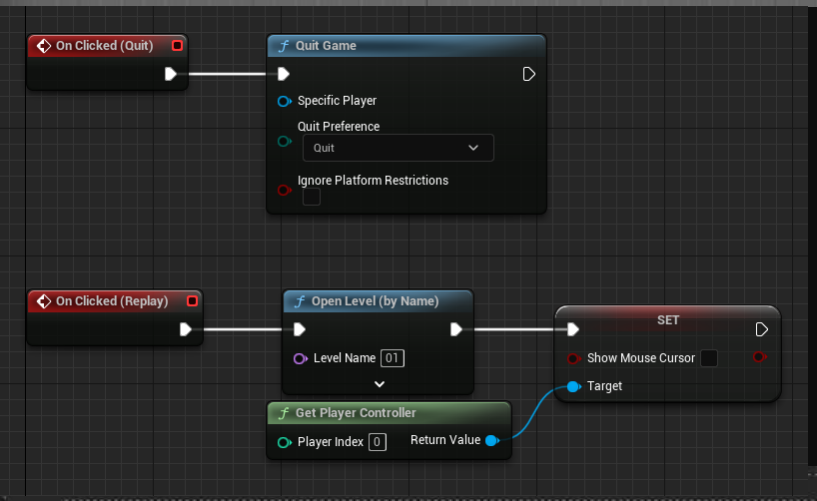
Same concept as above but actors destroyed after.









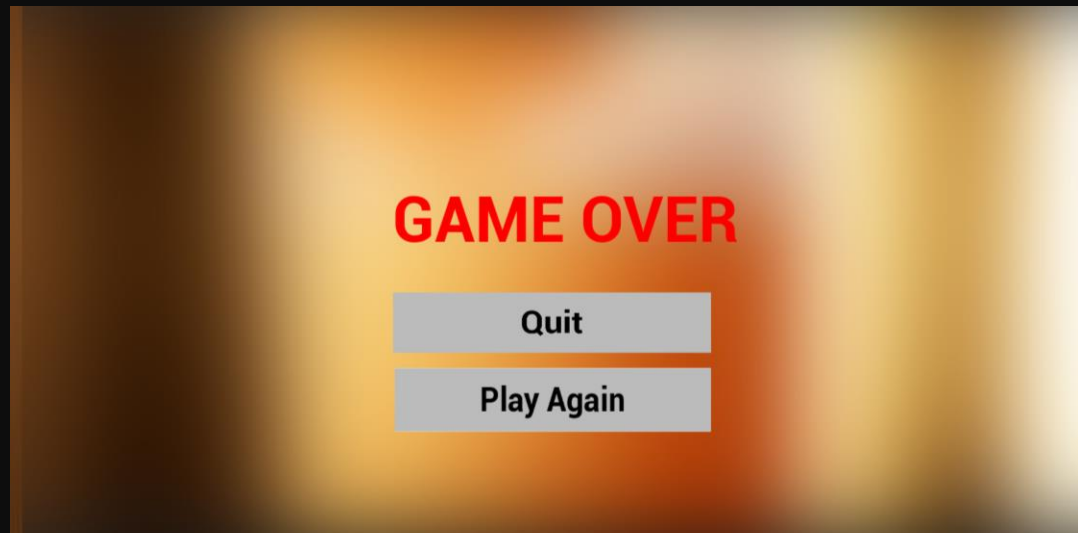


When quit is clicked the game will close. When replay is clicked it will reload the level.

When box overlapped the widget will be shown and game will pause.



Widget design and in game appearance.



Revisions and Feedback

After Playtesting and receiving feedback from friends and flat mates, here are some of the things I changed about my level:

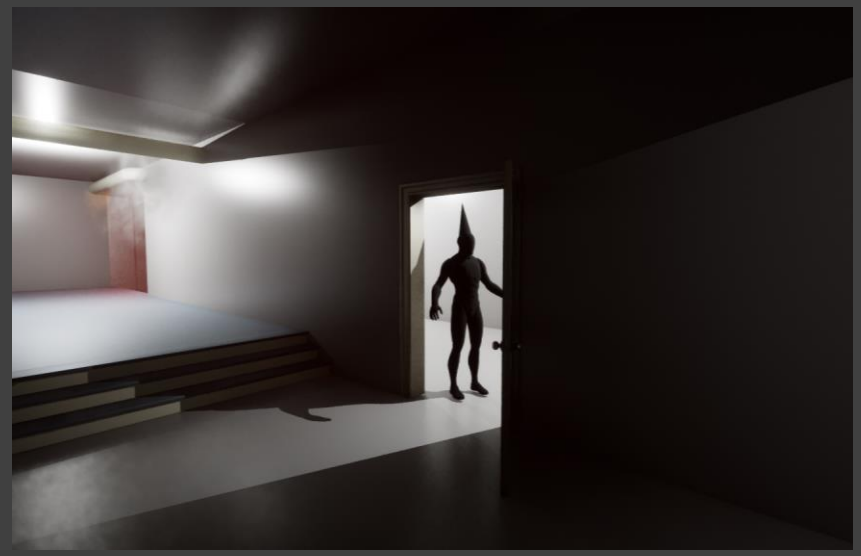
Initially I had made the clown silhouette from the starter content statue prop. On receiving feedback I found this looked too cartoonish and unserious so I swapped it for the SKM_Manny asset which looked a lot more life like. I also switches out the big red light behind it as it was distracting.



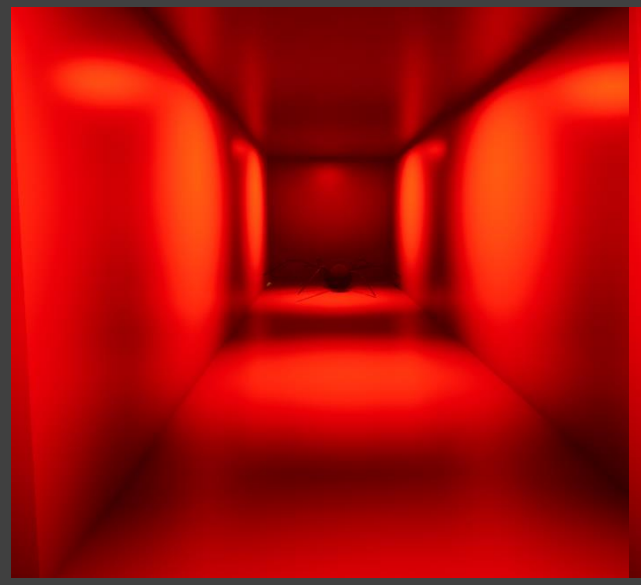
I also switched out the lighting from warm white to cool white. I had wanted to use warm white to give the level a sort of 'backrooms' feel but I inevitably decided that cool white just simply looks better.

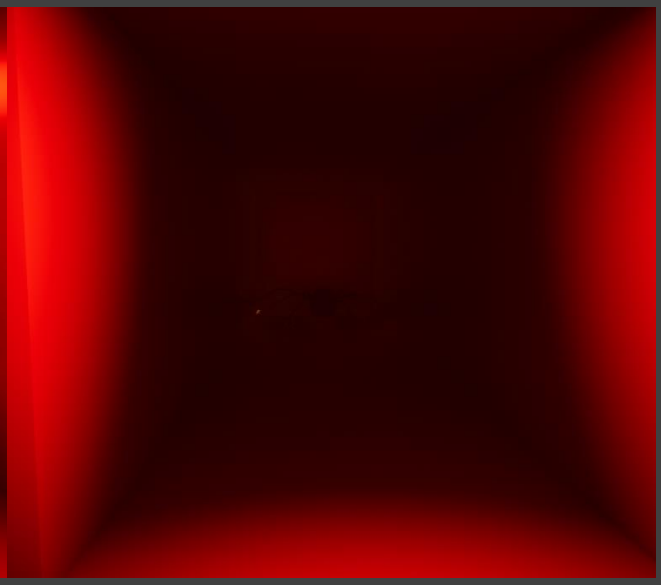


The AI on the second floor down was originally animated. It was by mistake that I removed it, but I found it was a lot more terrifying this was. My initial idea was it to be mannequins that follow the player, so having the AI lifeless was a lot more fitting.



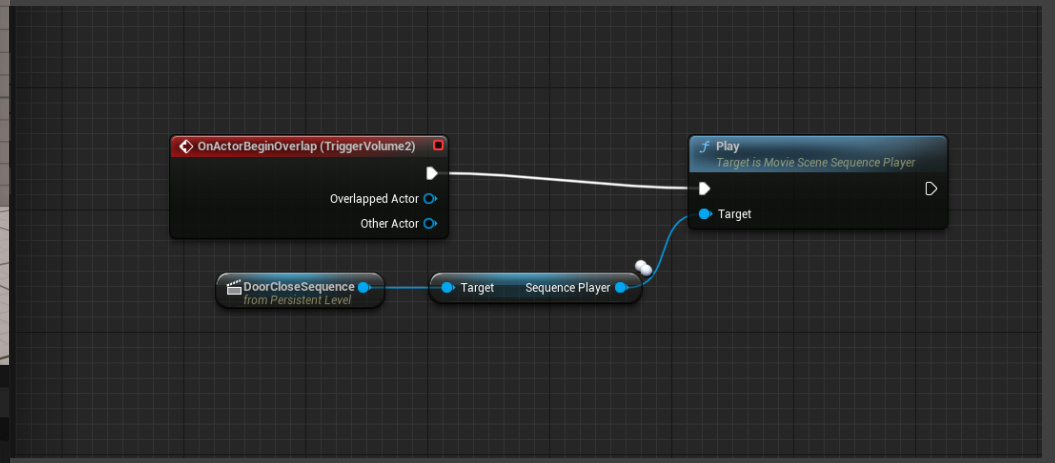
I also had lots of red lighting around the spider model, I found this a bit overwhelming, and it also made it obvious that the spider was not animated. I've since removed two lights so that it looks a bit more subtle whilst it emerges from seemingly nowhere.





I had initially used a sequencer to open the doors. Since I had planned to have multiple doors in my level, this turned out not be the most effective way as I would have to individually create a sequence for each door. I later replaced this with a timeline blueprint to give the same animation effect.





Evaluation

On evaluation, I am overall happy with the way my level turned out. It definitely fit with the initial idea I set for myself and all the main mechanics function perfectly. Despite this, there are things that if I had more time, I would change about my level. One thing I'd like to work on is lighting techniques as this is so important in making a game aesthetically pleasing and can do a lot for environmental storytelling. I would also love to work more on animation, my level was lacking in moving things that catches the eye. Moving forward I am eager to experiment more with unreal engine and add mechanics like cut scenes and subtitles. There were some issues I never got round to resolving, such as glitching textures in walls, and sound playing multiple times when spam interacting with doors. In the future I will need to learn to debug these if I plan on taking programming further. Overall I fit the expectation I set myself and went from knowing nothing about unreal engine to making a functioning level within 5 months.

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